

STEVE WEEKS PRESS CLIPPINGS

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Photos by Kristin Hicks

Steve Weeks gets kids up on their feet

Over the summer, the Alamosa Public Library has been promoting literacy through its summer reading program, "Libraries Rock." For one of its final weeks of the program this summer, the library hosted Steve Weeks, left, who writes songs for children to sing and dance to and that have fun-filled messages.



Kids in the crowd hop and dance along "Like a kangaroo" during a special program by the Alamosa Public Library on Wednesday.

Library program offers storytelling music

By DK McDONALD

THE DAILY NEWS

LAUGHLIN — The Laughlin Library wants children to learn that there is more than one way to hear a story.

"Reading a book is one way," said Eralm Reinhart, children's services assistant. "There are also songs and plays and puppet shows."

On Monday, the library's Summer Reading Program showcased the whimsical, musical storytelling of award-winning

songwriter and performer Steve Weeks.

"The very best part of participating in the Summer Reading Program is the kids," Weeks said. "Working with kids means I get to see things you normally don't get to see in a regular job, like kids who tell me they want to sing 'Frozen' forever, or kids who just can't stop dancing. It's great."

Featuring a series of original acoustic songs, the Colorado-based artist's show encourages the

participation of children and adults through song, musical games, and dance.

"The tradition I grew up in included music as a family thing, and I write my shows to engage the parents as well," Weeks said. "If I were to sing something like 'Itsy Bitsy Spider,' all the parents would be tapping away on their cell phones and tune out. I want to encourage the tradition of experiencing music as a family, so I encourage

them to sing and dance together."

Bobby Millikan said, "It was very entertaining and very good. The girls really got involved."

"I liked the song where he went really fast," said 6-year-old Abigail Millikan.

This is the third year Weeks has worked with the Las Vegas-Clark County Library District for the Summer Reading Program.

See LIBRARY, A3



DK McDONALD/The Daily News

STORY TIME: Las Vegas-Clark County Library District offered musical storytelling by award-winning songwriter and performer Steve Weeks on Monday as a part of the Summer Reading Program. Featuring a series of original, acoustic-based songs, the Colorado-based artist encouraged the participation of children and adults through song, musical games and dance.

Sweet sounds of diversity

Centennial students turn field trip to Bent's Old Fort in La Junta into a song



CAROL LAWRENCE, THE GAZETTE

From left, Centennial Elementary School students Shine Smith, Rose Niyimbabazi, Robert Sowa and Jiselle Aldrete record a song last week. The recording will be used in a National Park Service CD. The recording was made by Steve Weeks, a local musician with a recording studio.

BY CAROL MCGRAW
carol.mcgraw@gazette.com

What do you get when you mix grass, mud, sand, water, history and a lot of enthusiasm?

For students at Centennial Elementary School, it was a chance to be songwriters and recording stars for a National Park Service project.

In August, they visited Bent's Old Fort, a national historic site in La

VIDEO ONLINE



To view Eric Singer's video of Centennial Elementary School students singing, scan this QR code with your mobile

device or go to gazette.com.

Junta, where they learned about the history of the old adobe building that was an important crossroads of the Santa Fe Trail in the early 1800s.

If the kids had taken nothing away from the visit but the history lesson, it would have been an academic success. More than 90 percent of the students at Centennial are impoverished and, in many cases, have not had many cultural field trips.

Those on the excursion are members of Centennial's cultural diversity club and focused on how those at Bent's Fort — whites, Native Americans, Mexicans, African-Americans

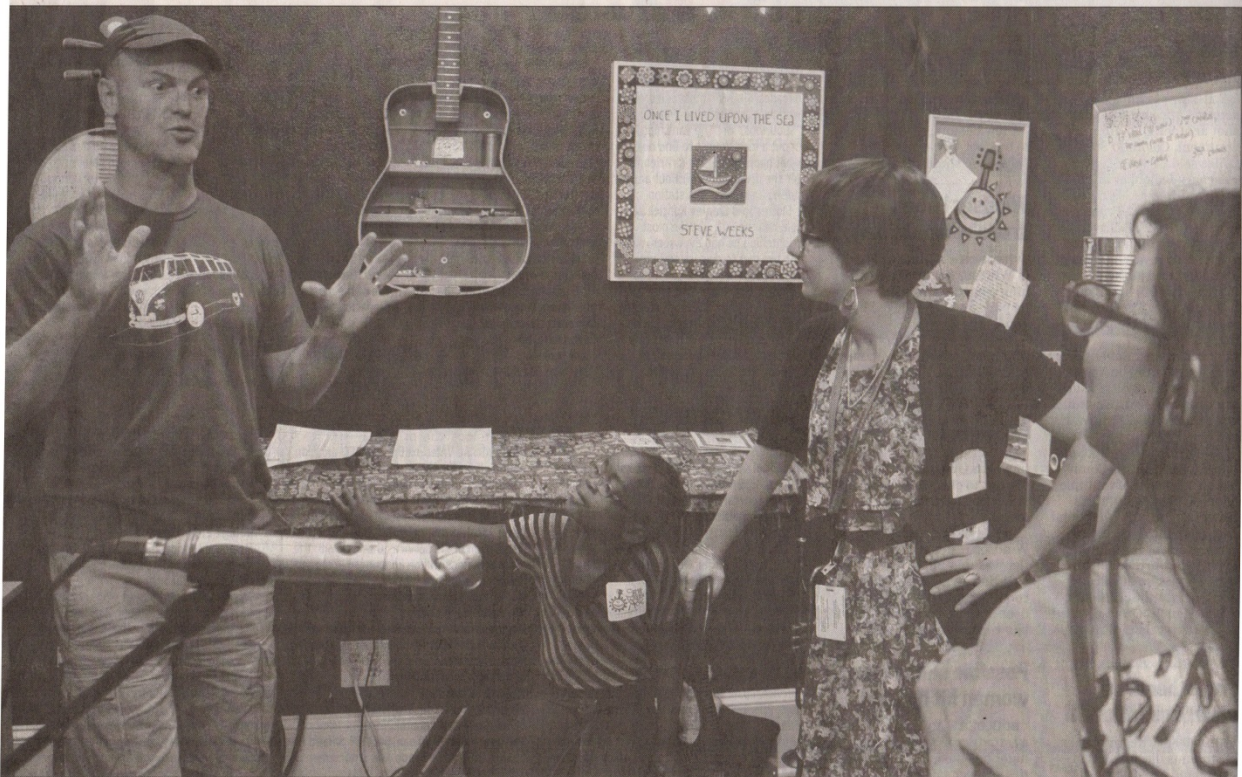
— worked and traded peacefully together.

Such diversity ties in with their diverse school experience (42 percent Hispanic, 22 percent white, 21 percent black, 10 percent mixed race, about 1 percent American Indian, 1 percent Asian and 3 percent Hawaiian or Pacific Islander).

One of the highlights of the trip,

SEE SINGING • PAGE 5

LOCAL & STATE



Local musician Steve Weeks speaks to Centennial Elementary School students Rose Niyimbabazi, center, and Jiselle Aldrete, far right, and music teacher Virginia Hudak after recording a song last week under the direction of Jeff Wolin, lead interpreter at the Florissant Fossil Beds National Monument.

SINGING

FROM PAGE 1

everyone agreed, was getting a chance to make their own adobe bricks. It was that adobe and the historical spirit of cooperation they learned about that inspired them to write "Castillo de Lodo, the Castle of Mud."

The song the students have written and are recording could be heard across the country eventually.

It started this summer when Julissa Vega, an instructional coordinator at Harrison School District 2, participated for several weeks in a Teacher Ranger Teacher program at Florissant Fossil Beds National Monument.

It is part of a nationwide program that links educators with classroom learning resources available at park service sites. Most of the teachers are from underserved student populations in urban and rural districts, said Jeff Wolin, lead interpreter at Florissant.

Wolin had received an Albright-Wirth grant from the National Park Service to expand his music writing skills with children. Part of the grant paid for the Centennial field trip, part funded the recording sessions.

THE SONG

"Castillo de Lodo, the Castle of Mud" (Verse 2 and the chorus)

Trappers and traders
hunters and freighters
servants and cooks and
a blacksmith or two
Mexican laborers Native
Americans
cultures combined like a
buffalo stew

Castillo de Lodo, the
castle of mud
Castillo de Lodo they
mixed up the mud
and added el agua,
zacate, arena el sol y
tiempo
Castillo de Lodo

"Music is a powerful medium, a great way to teach kids and something they will remember," Wolin said. "The idea was to take them somewhere rich in cultural history and write a song through their eyes."

In 2012, Wolin helped coordinate and produce an award-winning CD called "Songs for Junior Rangers, Part 1, paid for in part by Friends of Florissant Fossil Beds, Colorado Outdoor Education Center and The Na-

"Music is a powerful medium, a great way to teach kids and something they will remember."

Jeff Wolin, lead interpreter at Florissant

tional Park Foundation. He is pursuing a grant to create a second album for the 100th birthday of the national park system in 2016. The Centennial song would be part of that.

"We thought parks everywhere could use this project as a blueprint to create their own songs for it," Wolin said.

On the bus ride home from Bent's Old Fort, Wolin and Centennial music teacher Virginia Hudak worked with the students to brainstorm a theme and title. One student recalled seeing a sign that called the fort a "castle of mud." That settled the name. They also wanted to incorporate Spanish language into the music.

"Mixing the grass and mud, sand and water became a metaphor for cultural diversity in the lyrics," said Frances Gomeztagle, a Centennial counselor who was on the trip.

By the time they got back to town, they had the chorus and some of the verses. The kids, with adult help, continued to work on the song, striving to convey not only brickmaking but building a diverse community.

This month, four Centennial students who auditioned were chosen to record the song — Rose Niyimbabazi, third grade; Shine Smith, fourth grade; and Robert Sowa and Jiselle Aldrete, fifth grade.

They spent last weekend memorizing the updated lyrics and had them down pat by Monday. Wolin arranged with Steve Weeks, a Colorado Springs songwriter and producer of children's songs, to oversee the recording at his studio.

The kids were thrilled. "It is so cool," said Shine, getting a close-up view of the recording equipment.

Before the session started, Weeks passed out apple juice. "It helps the voice," he said.

At first, the children were shy in front of the microphone but quickly got over it as they practiced shouting out some of the song's bridge words.

"Fandango," Rose, 8, said softly as she began recording one of her parts.

"Yell it like you are at a party," Weeks instructed.

"Fandango!" she yelled.

"Fandango!"

And so it went.

"I felt really happy when I heard my voice," Rose said. "It was really loud, and I liked that."

When the project is finished, the cultural diversity club will have a party and receive personal copies. The song will be posted in late September or early October at the Florissant Fossil Beds website: www.nps.gov/flfo/forkids/downloads.htm.

Jiselle summed up the experience this way: "It's creative, and I learned a lot. I love history, and we got to see where people who were here before us lived."

Shine, 9, had his rock star take on all the excitement surrounding the project. "I like to sing and be interviewed."

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Children's Musician Steve Weeks

Music is Educational, Brings Families Together

BY KARA MARTINEZ BACHMAN

On June 13, children's musician Steve Weeks performed for a group of local South Mississippi kids for "Steve Weeks in Concert," held at Lynn Meadows Discovery Center in Gulfport. A singer, songwriter and guitarist who tours nationally, Weeks has four tracks that have reached No. 1 on Sirius XM's "Kids Place Live" channel. Weeks also came in first place -- with his song "Up!" -- in the children's music category of the U.S. Songwriting Competition. He has recorded multiple albums of acoustic guitar numbers designed to appeal to children as well as adults, including a trio of recordings known as the "Alphabet Song Series" and the albums "Dandelion" and "Once I lived Upon the Sea."

Weeks agreed to participate in a Q&A with "Parents & Kids" about his recent appearance in South Mississippi, and explained why he thinks music should be an important component of the education of all children.

Was this your first time performing in South Mississippi?

"Yes. It was part of a Gulf Coast tour that took me to New Orleans, Gulfport and Fairhope, Alabama. This was my first time performing in the Gulf Coast area."

Do you have any feedback on the local audience and how they received you?

"The audience there was wonderfully kind and receptive. The kids were very interactive and engaged, and the parents were all so kind and chatted after the show ... great folks there! I should also say that the hospitality at the Lynn Meadows Discovery Center was amazing. I perform at a lot of venues across the U.S. and Canada, and it's a top-notch theater for family entertainment. You guys are really lucky to have that place in your community."

In your opinion, why is introducing kids to really great age-appropriate music so important?

"I'm probably biased, but I think exposing your kids to music is extremely important. Even if your kids are not destined to be



musicians, just being around it engages the creative part of your brain. Learning about music enhances problem solving and translation. People who have been exposed to music do better in things like computer programming and foreign language acquisition. Not to mention that it's fun and brings you together as a family."

Are there specific suggestions you have for parents on ways they might want to really engage their kids when it comes to music?

"If there are music programs -- choir, band, orchestra -- in your kid's school, support it and encourage them to participate. Take your kids to concerts. Have a piano in your house and let your kids play on it even if they're just plunking around. I personally think ukuleles are great instruments for kids because the strings and size are easy for little fingers. It's a great introduction to stringed instruments. Most importantly, if you ever learned an instrument, play it once in while. Having music in your home will encourage kids to want to make music themselves."

Are there any musicians hailing from the state of Mississippi (Jimmie Rodgers, Elvis, Muddy Waters, B.B. King, Ike

Turner, Marty Stuart, etc.) who have had a particular influence on you or your music?

"Certainly Elvis. Man, I wish I played the guitar well enough to say I was influenced by B.B. King, but that wouldn't be fair to him. Being from the Carolinas originally, I'm definitely influenced by James Taylor and bluegrass."

What have you learned about all this as a result of being a performer?

"Music can bring families together. It does not have to be something that parents and kids listen to separately. At some point in every show, I get the parents up and dancing with their kids. It's wonderful to see that. There is lots of family-appropriate music out there that everyone can enjoy."

More information on Steve Weeks and his music can be found at SteveWeeksMusic.com.

KARA MARTINEZ BACHMAN is a writer, editor, and fan of all sorts of music. She agrees with Steve Weeks that music is important, and her children -- both of whom play the ukelele -- are proof that any child can easily learn at least one simple musical instrument.

SANTA YNEZ VALLEY NEWS - JULY, 2014

(Solvang, CA)

'World of Music' comes to Solvang

Staff Report Jul 1, 2014 0



f t e p v

Steve Weeks brought a "World of Music" with him last week to the Solvang Library as part of the summer reading program.

In his first performance in Solvang, the Colorado-based musician put on an interactive show with music, humor and games for children and grown ups.

A self-taught musician, Weeks sang several original songs including "My Dog Ate My House" and "Kiki Kangaroo" for several boys and girls and their parents. There was also a dance-off between boy and girls.

Sponsored by Friends of the Library, the summer reading program continues through July 31.

To prepare the library's entry in Friday's Fourth of July parade, the library is hosting craft workshops from 3 to 4 p.m. today and Wednesday.

"Bubble Factory!" is this year's theme for the entry. Children up to 6 years old should be joined by an adult or teen. Materials will be provided.

"The Nifty Balloon Show," a family-friendly variety show with music, storytelling, comedy and balloon sculptures, is scheduled for 10:30 a.m. Wednesday.

For more information, call the library at 688-4214 or visit the library calendar at www.sbplibrary.org.

f t e p v

Tags **Solvang**

Crested Butte News

Noon Year's Eve bash for kids and families

Take a lunch break from the slopes and celebrate the "Noon" Year with your kids on Monday, December 31 at the Mountaineer Square Ballroom, located at the ski area base.

This first Kids Rock concert of the season features Steve Weeks, a Colorado-based singer-songwriter who has a special knack for entertaining kids.

Weeks has three song tracks that have reached number one on Sirius XM's Kids Place Live and is known for his boisterous sense of humor and a deep sense of purpose that both educates and entertains.

The Noon Year's Eve Bash begins at 11 a.m. and also includes hands-on art activities, science projects and healthy kids' cuisine. Tickets are available for purchase at the door and cost \$10 per person, including lunch and all entertainment.

The third annual Kids Rock series is presented by the Trailhead Children's Museum and Crested Butte Music Festival and is sponsored by Crested Butte Mountain Resort and the town of Mt. Crested Butte.

Series underwriters include



Steve Weeks

Alley Hats, The Last Steep, Pooh's Corner, Pfister's Handworks, Little Red School House, Donita's Cantina, Elk Avenue Dental Center, Lavish, Petite Lavish, Milky Way, Maxwell's, django's, Bacchanale, Moore Orthopedics, Peak Properties and Abba Eye Care.

There also will be a Kids Rock concert "Aloha in the Butte" on March 16. For more information, go to www.crestedbuttemusicfestival.com or www.trailhead-kids.org.

MUSICAL NOTES

By Charlotte Bohn

Naturally Good

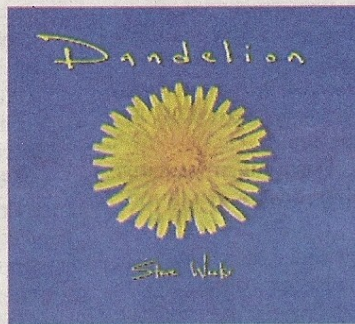
The weather is warming up, and summer is almost officially here. The three wonderful CDs and one DVD I reviewed this month celebrate the beauty of the Earth, the outdoors, family, and life in general.

Dandelion

www.steveweeksmusic.com

I can't stop listening to this CD. Simply put, it makes me happy.

From the opening track of tweeting birds leading into the title track with a smooth and mellow acoustic guitar riff and these lyrics, "I might be a bother, but I try really hard/ To bring a little color to an ordinary yard/ Everybody got a part to do/



"They call me a weed but it's just not true," Steve Weeks' *Dandelion* is a true flower among weeds. With an inviting voice that oozes warmth, Weeks is an inventive lyricist who easily flits from sentimental songs about the joys of a best friend ("A Friend Like You") to the humorous tale of a boy who refuses to bathe ("Bartleby Finkleton Will Not Take a Bath").

If you want to brighten up your children's music collection, pick *Dandelion*.

The Family Garden

www.thebillykellyshow.com



Whimsical, zippy, and upbeat, Billy Kelly's family album *The Family Garden* will perk up little ones' ears with songs that are a little off the beaten path.

Displaying a quirky sense of humor, Kelly has a

SCHOOL LIBRARY JOURNAL – 2010

(National Publication)

Multimedia Review

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Music

Dandelion. CD. 40:16 min. Prod. by Steve Weeks Music. Dist. by CDBaby.com. 2010. ISBN unavail. \$14.97.

PreS-Gr 3—Award-winning musician Steve Weeks presents 11 songs with toe-tappin' beats. He uses his lovely baritone voice and his exceptional performance on acoustic guitar in a variety of musical styles, such as folk, rock, rap, reggae, country, and bluegrass. Novelty sound effects enhance several of the tunes. His songs tell short stories, as in "Dandelion"—is it a weed or a colorful addition to the yard? "Bartleby Finkleton Will Not Take a Bath," and listeners are treated to graphic descriptions of just how dirty he is. "My Dog Ate My House" and all the contents therein. Weeks tells several tall tales in "I Might Be Lying," and claims he started "The Blizzard of '78." Among the other songs are "A Friend Like You," "Birdsong" (a long list of various birds), and "Why." A humorous album that is sure to be a hit in library music collections.—Beverly Wrigglesworth, San Antonio Public Library, TX

SUFFOLK NEWS HEARALD – JANUARY 16, 2009

(Suffolk, VA)

Songsmith and children's favorite Steve Weeks, whose song "Kiki Kangaroo" hit No. 1 on Kids' XM Radio, will play at 11 a.m. at the Suffolk Center for Cultural Arts. Weeks specializes in songs for families and kids. His music ranges from folk to 50s rock to reggae. His "Alphabet Songs" dedicate a song to each letter of the alphabet. Other tunes teach lessons about important things like courage, tolerance, pancakes, kangaroos, patience and friends. Tickets are \$7 for children, with adults admitted free.

SUMMIT DAILY NEWS – AUGUST 13, 2007

(Breckenridge, CO)

'Alphabet Songs' featured in today's Kidz Calliope Series event

DAILY NEWS STAFF REPORT

August 13, 2007



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The Mountain Top Children's Museum, Inc. hosts singer/songwriter Steve Weeks, with his original music that dedicates a single song to each letter of the alphabet, at The Riverwalk Center in Breckenridge today from 5:45-8 p.m. as part of the 2007 Kidz Calliope Series.

There will be a pre-entertainment activity workshop for children and barbecue from 5:45-6:45 p.m. and then a performance from Steve Weeks from 7-8 p.m.

Over the last five years, Weeks has created three CD's covering all the letters of the alphabet filled with songs that are upbeat and catchy, and bounce around in your head for days. Weeks has done several performances in schools, libraries and various events throughout Colorado.

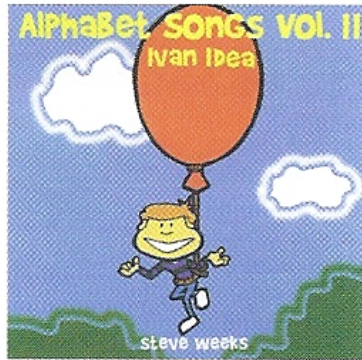
Tickets are \$5 and may be purchased at the Riverwalk Center box office, 150 W. Adams, or call (970) 547-3100 for advance reservations. Presented by the Town of Breckenridge, Kidz Calliope is sponsored by Summit Daily News, Colorado Mountain Express, RSN, and Parent's Handbook. Summit County. No pets are allowed at Riverwalk Center events.

For a complete schedule of events visit www.townofbreckenridge.com.

STEVE WEEKS: *Alphabet Songs 1 & 2:*

I am in awe of this guy's work! He was born to do what he's doing! He has recorded two CDs where each song on the CD deals with a letter of the alphabet. In less gifted hands, this could have been cheesy; in his hands, it's genius! The first CD covers letters A-H, and his second covers I-Q. He promises to finish the alphabet on his next release. He's so good, I hope he sets out to do a song for each number next and doesn't stop till he's finished them all!

steveweeksmusic.com



Steve Weeks Alphabet Songs Vol 2 (Ivan Idea)



'I've an idea' says Ivan Idea, while Kiki Kangaroo 'kicks her heels up' & Professor Poidexter P. Puggleston

has a Prepostrapercopopulataportapipplephone. That's the kind of humorous, imaginative & tounge twisting lyrics you'll find on Steve Weeks second Alphabet Songs album (letters I - Q). Many children's artists write songs with alliteration, but Steve is making a whole career out of it...& he does it well. A mix of country, jazz, funk & mid-tempo rock with very interesting percussion & hooky guitar keeps it fresh & lively.

www.steveweeksmusic.com

The Sippy Cups

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Children's Tunes Revive Spirit of Punk Rock

by Melissa Block

ZESTY, ZOOMIN', ZINGY



***Alphabet Songs (Vol. I, II, III)* by Steve Weeks** (self-released on steveweeksmusic.com)

Steve Weeks dedicates each song on these CDs to a letter of the alphabet (volume I is A-H, volume II is I-Q, this latest is R-Z). It's up-tempo music, full of catchy beats and with a lot of clever wordplay and fun stories. Some of the songs struggle with the letter they're devoted to and sound a bit labored; with others, you don't notice that many of the words start with the same letter. Here's how Weeks describes his music: "Although my songs have a strong footing in folk music, I just can't resist squeezing that reggae bass line, '50s rock riff, African thumb piano or even a tin can into one of my tunes." Or, as the kids' music blogger Stefan Shepherd at zooglobber.com puts it: "To put the album in adult terms, I'd describe it as Barenaked Ladies meets Phish." I couldn't have said it better myself. (Note: Steve Weeks is a true one-man band. He wrote, recorded and played all the sounds on the album.)

Audio for Youth

Alphabet Songs Volume II (Ivan Idea).

2005. 48min. CD Baby, CD, \$12. 800-289-6923.

Gr. 2–4. Performer Steve Weeks, master of kooky and often ingenious wordplay, tackles letters *I* through *Q* in this collection of nine original songs. From the insanely imaginative title character, Ivan, to a resounding plea for “Quiet,” Weeks plays with the many possibilities of each letter. Animals play a prominent role in a number of songs. Two of the best, “Kiki Kangaroo” and “The Ostrich and the Owl,” incorporate unobtrusive, worthwhile lessons. The music is sometimes folksy, usually eccentric, and always distinctive. The same can be said of Weeks’ performance. His is a fresh, original voice that kids—and their parents—will appreciate. Weeks’ listeners, old and new, will undoubtedly look forward to his forthcoming assault on the remaining alphabet. *Alphabet Songs Volume I* is also available. —*Paul Shackman*

Fairy Moon: Songs of the Ring. 2005. CD Baby, CD \$15.99. 800-448-6369.

PreS. These 21 songs are a mix of originals by singer Maria Sangiolo, traditional tunes (“White Coral Bells,” “The Rattlin’ Bog”), poems set to music, and flute and harp interludes. As the title indicates, many of the songs center on the world of wee folk. Sangiolo’s strong

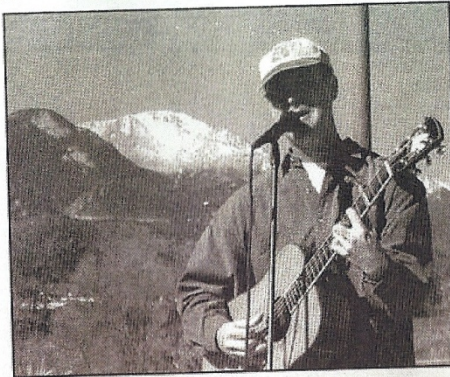
Music

Alphabet Songs, Vol. II: Ivan Idea. 1 CD.
47:10 min. Prod. by Steve Weeks Music.
Dist. by cdbaby.com. 2004. \$12.

PreS-Gr 2—The second in Steve Weeks' series of alphabet song CDs, this album offers nine tunes, each focusing on a letter from I to Q. The title track is the cleverest here: Ivan Idea is the kind of kid whose declaration of "I've an idea!" always leads to the most complicated—and funniest—solution to any problem. "Kiki Kangaroo" is a suitably bouncy tune about a kangaroo who doesn't like to be tied down. "Look, Look!" honors childlike wonder and curiosity. The four-part choral cacophony of "Quiet!" will entertain older kids. However, the letter associations in the other songs are a bit forced, as in the "rules for life" announced in "Never Take a Naked Mole Rat to Norway." Although the songs are fun, few teachers will find them useful in the classroom, and the unevenness of the songs will limit the CDs appeal as leisure-time listening.—*Kathleen Kelly MacMillan, Maryland School for the Deaf, Columbia*

MINNESOTA PARENT – 2004

(Minnesota)



Steve Weeks.

File photo

You say it's your birthday? Um, well, here's a CD?

By WILLIAM G. CHILDS

In a recent column, I wrote about a bunch of Brooklyn-based kids' artists, ranging from (relatively) huge stars like They Might Be Giants to indie family artists

Spare the Rock, Spoil the Child

pop with a light touch (think Luna

Steve Weeks: Alphabet Songs
Vols. 1 & 2. Steve Weeks took a fairly obvious concept — record a song for each letter of the alphabet (he's through "Q" so far) and has made it into two of the most irresistible albums we have.

He is, simply, a great songwriter and storyteller, with a warm voice and solid production values. With clever jokes, word play, varied instrumentation, and evocative vocals, the music puts me in mind of Barenaked Ladies.